CSS VISTA
WITH SADIA ZAHOOR & ALI HASSAN SARGANA

DAILY CURRENT AFFAIRS

PAKISTAN & THE WORLD

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DIPLOMACY / MIDDLE EAST

Iran keeps US messaging channel open as tensions climb

Tehran said indirect contacts continued while Washington and Israel weighed their next moves.

On Sunday, 25 October, Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said communications with the United States continued through intermediaries. He said Tehran remained open to diplomacy despite a prolonged interruption in negotiations. President Donald Trump said the United States would not strike Iran that day, although he offered no broader commitment about future action.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu warned that Iran or allied groups could try to interfere ahead of Israel's 27 October election. These statements took place against a background of renewed fears of military escalation and restrictions on shipping around the Strait of Hormuz. Neither a diplomatic breakthrough nor an agreement on security arrangements was announced.

BACKGROUND The present crisis follows a period of US-Iran military confrontation and disruption to regional shipping. Both diplomacy through intermediaries and military deterrence remain part of the states' public positions.

ANALYSIS Two different signals were visible: the stated availability of a diplomatic channel and continued warnings of force. A communication line can reduce miscalculation without producing a negotiated settlement. For Pakistan, the strategic concern lies in Gulf security, energy prices and the safety of commercial sea routes that link Asia to world markets.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Iran said intermediaries continued passing messages to Washington.

02 The US president ruled out an attack that day, not future action.

03 Israel faced a general election scheduled for 27 October.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs / International Relations — crisis diplomacy, regional security and energy routes

SOURCES Associated Press

AT A GLANCE

EDUCATION

Pakistan launched a merit-based scheme targeting 500,000 student Chromebooks.

DIPLOMACY

Iran said messages continued to pass to Washington through intermediaries.

REGIONAL SECURITY

Riyadh airport restarted some flights while Houthi attacks continued.

HEALTH

KP officials reported four mpox infections and planned contact tracing.

INVESTMENT

The ninth World Investment Forum opened in Doha.

01 PAKISTAN

SBP POLICY RATE	USD/PKR INTERBANK	KSE-100 CLOSE
11.50%	Rs 276.82 (bid quote)	162,374.87
14 SEP 2026 · SBP	23 OCT 2026 · BR	23 OCT 2026 · PSX

EDUCATION / DIGITAL POLICY

Pakistan launches 500,000-device youth Chromebook programme

The federal initiative links student devices with mobile internet connectivity and merit-based selection.

On Sunday, 25 October, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif formally launched the Youth Chromebooks Scheme in Islamabad. The government said it intended to distribute 500,000 refurbished Chromebooks over two years to eligible students, alongside bags and MiFi devices. The prime minister said allocation would be based on merit and would include learners at religious seminaries.

Officials described connectivity as part of the package rather than treating a laptop alone as sufficient digital access. Chairman of the Prime Minister's Youth Programme Rana Mashhood Ahmad Khan said internet connections for 500,000 recipients could indirectly benefit up to 2.5 million people. Those figures describe the programme's stated target, not devices already delivered.

BACKGROUND

Pakistan has run earlier laptop-distribution initiatives. The new programme combines hardware access with a portable internet connection.

ANALYSIS

Access to digital learning depends on reliable connectivity, training and continued equipment support. Distribution targets are an input measure: the more meaningful outcomes will be actual use in classrooms, student attendance, learning performance and fair access across regions.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Target: 500,000 refurbished Chromebooks over two years.

02 MiFi connectivity accompanies the student devices.

03 Programme scope includes students enrolled at religious seminaries.

CSS ANGLE Pakistan Affairs / Governance — education policy and digital inclusion

SOURCES Radio Pakistan · Geo News

FOOD SECURITY / PRICES

Food minister seeks stronger wheat-price monitoring

The administration linked market availability with a support-price policy aimed at growers.

On Sunday, 25 October, Minister for National Food Security and Research Rana Tanveer Hussain called for stronger market monitoring to maintain wheat availability and price stability. In remarks reported by Radio Pakistan, he described the recently fixed wheat price as an attempt to balance grower incentives with domestic supply concerns.

The minister said rising production costs had placed pressure on farmers during the previous two years. He expressed the expectation that the price policy would encourage cultivation and expenditure on farm inputs.

The statement did not establish the level of wheat held in storage or prove a subsequent change in consumer prices.

BACKGROUND

Wheat policy must deal with farmgate returns and retail affordability. Support prices, procurement arrangements and oversight can affect these groups differently.

ANALYSIS

Supply policy matters more than the announcement of a nominal price alone. Monitoring hoarding and ensuring the movement of grain are administrative tasks; whether such measures protect consumers depends on enforcement, transport costs and verifiable market data.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Rana Tanveer Hussain headed the federal food-security ministry.

02 Officials sought stronger monitoring of wheat availability.

03 The minister linked the price policy to grower investment decisions.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs / Economy — food inflation, agricultural policy and market regulation

SOURCES Radio Pakistan

PUBLIC HEALTH / SURVEILLANCE

KP reports four mpox infections without overseas travel

Health officials planned tracing and testing after laboratory results raised concerns over local transmission.

On Sunday, 25 October, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa health authorities were reported to have identified four mpox infections, including one married couple. Laboratory samples had tested positive on Saturday, 24 October, according to provincial health officials. The patients, three men and one woman, had no reported international travel history.

Two patients were from Nowshera, while Peshawar and Mardan accounted for one each. The provincial health department planned contact tracing and testing of close contacts. Officials also reported an annual provincial total of 18 infections after adding the four cases; this count was a reported surveillance total, not a forecast.

BACKGROUND

Mpox surveillance combines laboratory confirmation, case isolation, contact follow-up and reporting of links between infections.

ANALYSIS

Absence of overseas travel is a reason to investigate local chains of transmission, not conclusive proof of where infection occurred. Clear risk communication should distinguish confirmed tests from hypotheses and ensure contacts can access assessment without stigma.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Four newly reported cases included three men and one woman.

02 Patients came from Nowshera, Peshawar and Mardan.

03 Health officials planned tracing because local spread was possible.

CSS ANGLE General Science / Pakistan Affairs — communicable-disease surveillance

SOURCES Dawn

NATIONAL SECURITY / BALOCHISTAN

Security sources report militant commander killed in Qila Saifullah

The account concerns an intelligence-based operation and remains attributed to Pakistani security sources.

On Sunday, 25 October, Pakistani security sources said an intelligence-based operation in Balochistan's Qila Saifullah district had killed a militant commander identified as Adil Shah, also known as Darvesh. State media

and other outlets repeated the account, including allegations that he had handled finances for a banned militant group.

According to the security-source account, Shah had been linked to the group since December 2020 and had supervised financial work since 2024. The sources also alleged that he arranged accommodation for other militants. No independently adjudicated finding about each allegation was presented in the reports.

BACKGROUND

Intelligence-based operations are intended to act on specific security information. Balochistan has experienced a long-running threat of militancy and attacks on security personnel.

ANALYSIS

Financial networks and logistical support are often as important as armed operations in counterterrorism strategy. Attribution remains essential: an official account of a security operation is not the same as an independent judicial determination of responsibility for earlier offences.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Location: Qila Saifullah district, Balochistan.

02 The person named in security reports was Adil Shah alias Darvesh.

03 The operation was described as intelligence-based.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs / Pakistan Affairs — internal security and counterterrorism

SOURCES Geo News · Dawn

ENVIRONMENT / MUNICIPAL POLICY

Interior minister promises tree protection at Islamabad park

A statement on F-9 Park redevelopment answered public concerns about urban greenery.

On Sunday, 25 October, Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi said the proposed redevelopment of Islamabad's F-9 Park would not involve the removal of trees. Responding publicly to residents' concerns, he also stated that no new concrete structures would be added.

The minister outlined potential improvements including lighting, walking routes, a lake and further planting. The park is also known as Fatima Jinnah Park. The assurances were policy statements; they did not amount to an independently examined final environmental assessment or an audited implementation report.

BACKGROUND

Public debate over tree removal and green-space development has previously involved Islamabad civic authorities and the courts.

ANALYSIS

Urban parks provide cooling, recreation and ecological benefits. Transparent site designs, inventories of mature trees and accessible project documents can make public assurances testable. Redevelopment standards must protect existing ecosystems, not simply promise replacement saplings.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 F-9 Park is also called Fatima Jinnah Park.

02 Mohsin Naqvi pledged that trees would not be removed.

03 The proposed changes included improved public amenities.

CSS ANGLE Environmental Science / Governance — urban ecology and public accountability

SOURCES Dawn

GOVERNANCE / PUBLIC ASSETS

Punjab transfers Jhang deputy commissioner after vehicle row

A regulatory authority vehicle at a private rally prompted a disciplinary response.

On Sunday, 25 October, Punjab Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz announced the immediate removal from the Jhang deputy commissioner post of Babar Sahib Din. The decision followed video footage showing a Punjab Enforcement and Regulatory Authority (PERA) vehicle accompanying a jeep rally that had taken place earlier in October.

A notification from the Services and General Administration Department transferred the officer and directed him to report to the department for further orders. The chief minister said the use of a regulatory authority's vehicle beyond its mandate raised concerns about administrative discipline. The transfer is a reported administrative action, not a court finding of personal criminal liability.

BACKGROUND

PERA is a provincial enforcement body associated with regulatory functions including market controls and anti-encroachment operations.

ANALYSIS

Public vehicles, personnel and budgets exist for defined statutory duties. The dispute tests internal controls over asset allocation, reporting and supervision. Effective accountability also requires due process and clarity about who authorised an allegedly improper deployment.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Officer transferred: Jhang DC Babar Sahib Din.

02 The vehicle belonged to Punjab Enforcement and Regulatory Authority.

03 The transfer was notified on 25 October.

CSS ANGLE Governance / Public Administration — misuse of official resources and accountability

SOURCES Dawn · Minute Mirror

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02 WORLD

GLOBAL ECONOMY / UNCTAD

Doha opens ninth World Investment Forum

The UN-linked gathering focused on directing investment to development needs.

On Sunday, 25 October, the ninth World Investment Forum opened in Doha, Qatar. Qatar News Agency reported that Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman bin Jassim Al-Thani attended the inauguration. Qatar hosted the event in partnership with UN Trade and Development (UNCTAD).

The agency said more than 5,000 participants and 406 speakers were involved. The three-day programme, running to 27 October, addressed investment policy, entrepreneurship, sustainable finance, artificial intelligence and environmental sectors. Its official theme was 'Investing in the Future'.

BACKGROUND

UNCTAD is a United Nations body concerned with trade, investment and development. Large investment events connect public policy discussions with investors and firms.

ANALYSIS

The development question is not only how much capital crosses borders, but where it flows and whether it produces productive employment. Developing states can use such discussions to raise regulatory certainty, infrastructure needs and access to finance.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Ninth World Investment Forum: Doha, Qatar.

02 Dates: 25–27 October 2026.

03 QNA reported more than 5,000 participants.

CSS ANGLE International Relations / Economy — foreign direct investment and development

SOURCES Qatar News Agency

REGIONAL SECURITY / AVIATION

Riyadh airport resumes limited flights amid Houthi attacks

Two terminals restarted service while missile and drone threats continued.

On Sunday, 25 October, King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh restarted some passenger operations after a suspension associated with attacks by Yemen's Houthi forces. Reports identified Terminal 1 for domestic flights and Terminal 2 for international flights operated by national carriers.

The reopening was partial: flight-tracking reports indicated limited departures, and the security situation remained unsettled. Saudi authorities reported intercepting incoming weapons; Houthi spokespeople continued to issue threats against the airport. Reported claims from either side about military results should be read as attributed statements rather than independently established outcomes.

BACKGROUND

The Yemen conflict has spilled into neighbouring states through long-range missile and drone attacks on aviation and energy assets.

ANALYSIS

The same event can carry transport, security and economic effects. Even a partly open airport may face cancellations, insurance concerns and public fear. Stabilising civil aviation requires credible protection of civilian infrastructure as well as regional diplomacy.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Airport: King Khalid International Airport, Riyadh.

02 The restart involved Terminals 1 and 2.

03 Houthi threats persisted despite the reopening.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs / International Relations — Yemen conflict and critical infrastructure

SOURCES Dawn/AFP · Associated Press

INDIAN OCEAN / HUMANITARIAN DIPLOMACY

Sri Lanka repatriates 40 stranded Iranian sailors

Maritime medical assistance proceeded despite sanctions-related sensitivities.

On Sunday, 25 October, Sri Lanka's Foreign Ministry said 40 Iranian sailors had left for Tehran after receiving medical assistance. The crew had been brought ashore to the southern port of Galle on Saturday following a distress call from ships close to Sri Lankan waters.

Spokesperson Thushara Rodrigo said the Iranian embassy and local shipping agents arranged vessels to move the sailors, while Sri Lankan authorities handled immigration procedures. According to the report, ships associated with Iran had remained off the island amid a US naval blockade and concerns about secondary sanctions.

BACKGROUND

The Strait of Hormuz crisis affects shipping routes beyond the Gulf as vessels and crews seek safe ports and access to essential supplies.

ANALYSIS

Sri Lanka faced a humanitarian choice involving seafarer welfare and the prospect of economic consequences under sanctions. The response illustrates the distinction between giving emergency medical assistance to people and taking a position on a wider maritime dispute.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 40 Iranian sailors were repatriated.

02 The medical landing took place at Galle.

03 Repatriation followed treatment and occurred on 25 October.

CSS ANGLE International Relations / Law — maritime security, sanctions and humanitarian obligations

SOURCES Associated Press

GLOBAL HEALTH / BORDER MANAGEMENT

Uganda expands Ebola checks and quarantine rules

New travel controls responded to regional contagion risk and unresolved exposure histories.

On Sunday, 25 October, Uganda's Health Ministry announced tighter border and airport controls in response to Ebola infections in neighbouring countries. Ugandan citizens returning from the Democratic Republic of the Congo were required to undertake a 21-day quarantine at their own expense, according to the ministry's reported rules.

Authorities intensified screening at Entebbe International Airport and land crossings and required passenger locator information. Uganda also said investigators were still working with Nigeria to establish the movement and possible exposure history of a woman diagnosed with Ebola there. Officials did not claim to have established the route of infection.

BACKGROUND

Ebola containment rests on tracing contacts, infection-control precautions, clinical care and early detection during outbreaks.

ANALYSIS

Border restrictions can reduce opportunities for spread but also create economic and humanitarian costs. Effective systems need coordination with neighbouring states, reliable lab information and accessible support for people asked to isolate. The exact transmission chain must remain an open question until evidence resolves it.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 New quarantine period: 21 days for relevant returning citizens.

02 Controls included Entebbe airport and land crossings.

03 Uganda had not established the patient exposure route.

CSS ANGLE General Science / International Relations — epidemic preparedness and border policy

SOURCES Associated Press

HEALTH SYSTEMS / SOUTH ASIA

WHO details medicine-supply gaps across Bangladesh facilities

A newly released account examined the practical limits of electronic health logistics.

On Sunday, 25 October, the World Health Organization published details of an assessment conducted with Bangladesh's Directorate General of Health Services. Teams had examined medicine supplies and inventory procedures at 16 public health facilities during 13 September–5 October 2026.

The work reviewed the electronic Logistics Management Information System, or eLMIS, as well as storage and pharmacy practices. Initial observations included training and equipment shortages, parallel paper procedures and inconsistencies between stock records and physical inventories. WHO said the findings would inform further reforms; the assessment itself had taken place earlier than the publication date.

BACKGROUND

Electronic logistics systems track how medicines move into, through and out of health facilities. Systems are only as reliable as the records and personnel supporting them.

ANALYSIS

Digital recordkeeping alone cannot secure essential medicines. Staff competence, procurement discipline and storage conditions determine whether data correspond to supplies actually available for patients. The findings have regional significance for universal health coverage and resilient public-service delivery.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Assessment covered 16 public facilities.

02 WHO worked with Bangladesh DGHS.

03 The system reviewed was eLMIS.

CSS ANGLE General Science / Governance — public-health logistics and digital administration

SOURCES WHO Bangladesh

NEXT SEVEN DAYS

27 OCT Israel general election, in a tense regional security environment. Source

27 OCT World Investment Forum scheduled to conclude in Doha. Source

29 OCT UNEP plans to release its Restoration Progress Report at CBD COP17. Source

30 OCT CBD COP17 scheduled to close in Yerevan, Armenia. Source

03 GENERAL KNOWLEDGE

01 DIPLOMACY

Iran publicly described indirect communication with Washington as ongoing.

Source

02 EDUCATION

Pakistan announced a target of 500,000 refurbished Chromebooks.

Source

03 EDUCATION

The announced distribution horizon is two years.

Source

04 CONNECTIVITY

MiFi devices are intended to accompany Chromebooks.

Source

05 FOOD POLICY

Rana Tanveer Hussain served as federal minister for National Food Security and Research.

Source

06 PUBLIC HEALTH

KP officials reported four additional mpox infections.

Source

07 SURVEILLANCE

The four reported KP mpox patients had no international travel history.

Source

08 SECURITY

Qila Saifullah is the district named in the reported intelligence-based operation.

Source

09 ENVIRONMENT

Islamabad F-9 Park is also known as Fatima Jinnah Park.

Source

10 ADMINISTRATION

PERA stands for Punjab Enforcement and Regulatory Authority.

Source

11 ACCOUNTABILITY

The transferred Jhang deputy commissioner was Babar Sahib Din.

Source

12 UN ECONOMY

Doha hosted the ninth World Investment Forum.

Source

13 INVESTMENT

The Doha forum was scheduled for 25–27 October 2026.

Source

14 TRANSPORT

King Khalid International Airport is in Riyadh.

Source

15 MARITIME

Galle was the Sri Lankan port used to land the Iranian sailors.

Source

16 HEALTH

Uganda announced a 21-day quarantine measure for relevant returnees from Congo.

Source

17 DIGITAL HEALTH

Bangladesh health authorities examined 16 public facilities.

Source

18 DIGITAL HEALTH

eLMIS refers to the electronic Logistics Management Information System.

Source

04 FIVE TERMS

CONSTITUTION / POLITICAL SCIENCE

Separation of powers

The division of public authority among legislative, executive and judicial institutions. Its purpose is to prevent a single institution from controlling all key functions of government.

WHY IT MATTERS It helps distinguish institutional responsibility from mechanisms of checks and balances.

EXAMPLE Example: The US Constitution allocates legislative, executive and judicial functions to separate branches; its structure dates from 1787.

SOURCES Cornell LII

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS / TRADE

Most-favoured-nation treatment

The WTO non-discrimination principle generally requires comparable trade treatment for other WTO members once a benefit is extended to one member. WTO agreements permit specified exceptions, including some preferential trade arrangements.

WHY IT MATTERS It helps explain why trade preferences and tariff negotiations require treaty-based legal analysis.

EXAMPLE Example: Article I of GATT 1994 embodies the principle for trade in goods.

SOURCES World Trade Organization

ECONOMY / PUBLIC FINANCE

Primary fiscal balance

The overall government fiscal balance calculated without net interest payments. It focuses attention on the gap between non-interest spending and revenue, rather than inherited debt-service costs.

WHY IT MATTERS It is widely used to evaluate fiscal effort and debt sustainability.

EXAMPLE Example: An OECD fiscal account can report the primary balance separately from the overall balance for a given financial year.

SOURCES OECD

LAW / PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

Delegated legislation

Rules or other secondary legislation made under authority conferred by a statute rather than a new primary Act. The parent statute establishes the scope and conditions for this delegated power.

WHY IT MATTERS It is central to understanding regulatory rulemaking and parliamentary scrutiny.

EXAMPLE Example: The UK uses statutory instruments under powers authorised in Acts of Parliament.

SOURCES UK Parliament

ENVIRONMENT / ECOLOGY

Carrying capacity

The number of organisms a defined environment can support under specified resource and consumption conditions. Food, water, habitat and other constraints may alter the limit over time.

WHY IT MATTERS It helps assess population pressure, environmental management and sustainability.

EXAMPLE Example: Food scarcity can limit the sustainable size of a rabbit population in a particular habitat.

SOURCES National Geographic

05 PRACTICE

15 multiple-choice questions | Select the single best answer

01. How many Chromebooks were announced under Pakistan's new programme?

A. 250,000 B. 500,000
C. 750,000 D. 1,000,000

02. Over what period did the government propose distributing the Chromebooks?

A. Two years B. One year
C. Three years D. Five years

03. Where was the reported intelligence-based operation against Adil Shah conducted?

A. Nushki B. Khuzdar
C. Qila Saifullah D. Kalat

04. Which federal minister called for stronger wheat-price monitoring?

A. Muhammad Aurangzeb B. Ahsan Iqbal
C. Khalid Maqbool Siddiqui D. Rana Tanveer Hussain

05. How many new mpox infections did KP authorities report?

A. Four B. Six
C. Eight D. Ten

06. Which Islamabad park was the subject of the tree-protection assurance?

A. Lake View Park B. F-9 Park
C. Shakarparian Park D. Rose and Jasmine Garden

07. Which Punjab district's deputy commissioner was transferred over a PERA vehicle?

A. Kasur B. Mianwali
C. Jhang D. Okara

08. Which city opened the ninth World Investment Forum in October 2026?

A. Muscat B. Dubai
C. Manama D. Doha

09. Which edition of the World Investment Forum opened on 25 October?

A. Ninth B. Seventh
C. Tenth D. Eighth

10. How many Iranian sailors were reported repatriated from Sri Lanka?

A. 20 B. 40
C. 60 D. 80

11. Which Sri Lankan port received the sailors for medical assistance?

A. Colombo B. Trincomalee
C. Galle D. Hambantota

12. What quarantine duration did Uganda announce for relevant returnees from Congo?

A. 7 days B. 10 days
C. 14 days D. 21 days

13. Which two institutions carried out Bangladesh's medicine-supply assessment?

A. DGHS and WHO B. UNICEF and IMF
C. WTO and FAO D. UNDP and UNESCO

14. Which part of Riyadh's transport system resumed partial service?

A. Metro Line 3 B. King Khalid International Airport
C. King Abdulaziz Port D. North railway corridor

15. Which principle generally bars WTO members from discriminating among trading partners?

A. Local-content rule B. Capital control
C. Most-favoured-nation treatment D. Export licensing

05 ANSWER KEY

01 **B** · The announced nationwide target was 500,000 devices. Source

02 **A** · The prime minister described a two-year target. Source

03 **C** · Reports identified Qila Saifullah district in Balochistan. Source

04 **D** · Rana Tanveer Hussain held the food-security portfolio. Source

05 **A** · Provincial reporting identified four additional infections. Source

06 **B** · The statement concerned F-9, also known as Fatima Jinnah Park. Source

07 **C** · The official transfer concerned Jhang. Source

08 **D** · The World Investment Forum began in Doha, Qatar. Source

09 **A** · Qatar News Agency called it the ninth edition. Source

10 **B** · The foreign ministry spokesperson confirmed 40 sailors. Source

11 **C** · The sailors were brought ashore at Galle. Source

12 **D** · The announced quarantine duration was 21 days. Source

13 **A** · WHO described its work with the Directorate General of Health Services. Source

14 **B** · Airport Terminals 1 and 2 were designated for renewed operations. Source

15 **C** · MFN treatment is a core WTO principle of non-discrimination. Source

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